

Selling to Saps

On one of Jay Leno's last *Tonight* shows, he asked Octo-Mel (as in Oscar-winning actor-director Mel Gibson) what his new child from his Russian girlfriend was going to be. "A human being, I think," he replied, rolling his eyes crazily. Gibson may be a walking time-bomb, abusing Jews one day and chastising Christians in his church another, but he got this right. Too many parents forget to raise human beings and settle for conveyor-belt automatons. Much of it is the result of a thriving mommy-daddy industry across the world and now in India, where parenting workshops, self-help books and mother confessor blogs hog shelf and spectrum space. Time was when being a parent involved a whole lot of common sense, some skills as sergeant major and a bit of parental advice. No longer. What was once an art has become a science, in no small measure aided by the "other mother" syndrome which bureaucrat Chandra Iyengar spoke about at the INDIA TODAY Woman Summit earlier this year. This consists of children always pointing to their friends' mothers who bake cookies, keep a perfect house and look like a million bucks at PTAs. It doesn't help that your child is aware of yummy-mummies like Priyanka Gandhi, who not only make cupcakes for their children but also set off fashion trends. Or that the advertising world is determined to make the stern mother a sad Nirupa Roy stereotype—please recall the Airtel ad where the naughty child, when made to sit in a corner, complains to his father on a toy telephone and then believes that the bad mommy has been given an earful by the good dad. Granted that the ad world is full of men out to take revenge on their disciplinarian mothers, but really is this the thanks that mommies get?

Should your children be free range kids, allowed the liberty to play and explore, something our generation had while growing up, as Lenore Skenazy writes in her mouthful of an entertaining book, *Free Range Kids: Giving Our Children the Freedom We Had Without Going Nuts With Worry*? Or should they be put into regimented schedules which produce young ladies and gentlemen of discipline, as *Parenting by the Book* author and born again Christian John Rosemond advocates? Schools don't help by choking children with factory-ready moulds. Neither does society with its values forever in a state of flux. What are the poor parents supposed to do in an environment where group discussions with strangers are fast replacing dinner table family conversations and therapy sessions are taking the place of parent-child time-outs? I have a suggestion. Nothing you ever do will be good enough for these emerging super nannies, especially if you're a working mother. So just do what your own mommy did. Trust your instincts.

**SCHOOLS DON'T
HELP PARENTS BY
CHOKING KIDS
WITH FACTORY-
READY MOULDS.
NEITHER DOES
SOCIETY WITH ITS
VALUES FOREVER
IN A STATE OF FLUX.**



SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Vice-Admiral **Nirmal Kumar Verma**, 58, as the country's next chief of naval staff. During his 39 years of service, Verma has served in a variety of command, staff and instructional appointments, besides commanding aircraft carrier *INS Viraat*.

ELECTED: The BJP's tribal leader from Jharkhand, **Karla Munda**, 73, as the deputy speaker of the Lok Sabha. Seven-time member of Parliament, he represents Khunti in the 15th Lok Sabha.



DIED: **Rajeev Motwani**, the 47-year-old Indian-American computer science professor at Stanford University who mentored Google's co-founders, in a freak drowning accident at his home in California.

APPOINTED: Senior advocate and former solicitor general **Goolam E. Vahanvati** as the new attorney-general of India. He is the first Muslim to hold this post.

WON: The French Open men's doubles title by **Leander Paes** and his Czech partner **Lukas Dlouhy**. It is Paes's ninth Grand Slam title.

